

Acres

written by

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EXT. CREEKSIDE - DAY

Close up shot

A WORM wriggles aside a fishing HOOK with RUSSELL (15yr boy, 1862 birth year) dirty hands struggling to harpoon the side.

ALICIA (V.O.)
Why is it always fishing? Ugh.
Mind-traveling can be so boring
sometimes.

ABIGAIL (O.S.)
It's squirming. It's not supposed
to do that.

RUSSELL
Stay still little fella. This ain't
going to to kill you the fish will.

ABIGAIL (V.O.)
Would you stay still if I tried to
harpoon you.

WIDE ANGLE: Russell holds the hooked worm like a trophy as he grabs the converted stick, a fishing rod.

RUSSELL
Why would you harpoon me?

ANGLE ON: ABIGAIL (14yrs, girl, 1862 birth year) sitting under a REED built shelter surrounded by dirt.

ABIGAIL
You've given more reasons than I
can count.

RUSSELL
That's not really high.

Russell places the rod down and walks towards Abigail.

RUSSELL (CONT'D)
One. Two. Three. When you're out of
fingers. Dad! Dad! I need more
fingers. He'll tell ya to count
your toes.

Russell plots himself down under the shelter. He nudges Abigail over for space. She pushes back, then presses herself up off the ground and AWAY from the shelter.

ALICIA (V.O.)
You got this Abigail.

POV: Abigail brushes dirt off her hands.

ANGLE ON: Russell intently watches Abigail make the way to pick up the rod. He JUDGES her stance, gait, and preparation.

RUSSELL

Don't catch the trees. We ain't got any extra string. Put it left of the rocks or it'll get caught.

ABIGAIL

How bout I put it right ...

(pause)

Into your mouth. I'm better at this than you.

ALICIA (V.O.)

Fishing is where you two have the best arguments ... I love this place!

Abigail casts the line.

CLOSE ON: The worm twirls in the air then FALLS towards the water. Splash!

ANGLE ON: Abigail spins a 540 as the worm sinks behind into the CREEK. She moseys back to the shelter. Her hand swooshes Russell to the side as she sits under the shelter.

IMAGE: 'Ruzzel' is carved into the dirt. A nail punch in a small TIN CAN is aside the words.

ANGLE DOWN: Abigail glances down towards her brother who is leaning low and staring out at the fishing rod.

ABIGAIL

Do you know how to spell you name?

RUSSELL

(frustrated)

I know I can't find my pocketknife.
I know I'm hungry.

ABIGAIL

(shocked)

You ate twice this morning.

RUSSELL

Eggs don't fill me up because I got to get them from the hens in the morning.

ABIGAIL

Stop thinking about food. There are more important things in life - like clothes. I thought about wearing my Sunday best a day early.

Russell shakes his head as Abigail highlights her topic.

ABIGAIL (CONT'D)

I'd wear my blue ruffle dress; white lace down the arms with flowers on the underside. Flip my palms over and see a garden from elbow to wrist, wildflowers, daisies and roses. I'd wear a corset.

ALICIA (V.O.)

Croissant?

RACHEL (V.O.)

Alicia!

LOW RUMBLE of THUNDER.

CLOSE ON: Russell turns his head to stare at the gray sky.

RUSSELL

Was that thunder?

ABIGAIL

(solemnly)

Great. Ten minutes to walk home.

(sigh)

I'm gonna get all muddy.

ANGLE UP: Russell glances to his sister as RAIN PELTS his face and speckles the dirt. Lightning CRACKS!

RUSSELL

Nothing takes that long to get muddy. I could muddy that blue dress in under a minute.

ABIGAIL

Why would you be in my dress?

RACHEL (V.O.)

ALICIA!

CUT TO BLACK.

EXT. TREEHOUSE - DAY

ANGLE DOWN: RACHEL (late 30s, wife, mother of three) glances up at the LARGE TREEHOUSE where her only daughter ALICIA (14yrs, girl) is laying on the Treehouse DECK.

RACHEL
You're late for dinner. Everyone's waiting.

ALICIA
I'm coming down.

Alicia rolls to her side to leave the treehouse.

RACHEL
Make it quick!
(scanning the yard)
Daughter? Why does my yard look like a gopher field?

ANGLE ON: Alicia DISMOUNTS the treehouse steps. She puts a POCKETKNIFE into her pocket. She smiles at Rachel as the two walk towards the house. A WILLOW TREE and REMNANTS of STONE FARMHOUSE on the right. A garden on the left with two scarecrows in BLUE and one scarecrow in PINK overalls.

RACHEL (CONT'D)
Are you going to answer my question?

ALICIA
Maybe yes... Probably not today.

RACHEL
So what were you digging today?
Treasure? Fossils?

TRACKING SHOT: Alicia and Rachel walking past the FARMHOUSE with an open ORCHARD in the background. One patch of grass is not mowed.

ALICIA
None of the above. Just fishing at the creek with Russell and-

RACHEL
Whose Russell? If you have boys over, then I should probably know.

ALICIA
No one you know. Doubt I'll see him again till he washes up. His nails were hid-e-ous.
(MORE)

ALICIA (CONT'D)
He hadn't cleaned them in decades
which is saying something because
he's my age.

A patch of yard was MISSED by the mower.

RACHEL
(looking aside to Alicia)
The maestro of the mower missed
more spots than you dug up.

ALICIA
Hey. (pausing) You're right let's
focus on him.
(silently)
Not me.

ANGLE ON: KYLE (late 30s, male, husband) holds open the
sliding door to the LARGE WOOD DECK on the TWO-STORY HOUSE.
Rachel catches his eye as her and Alicia walk onto the deck.

KYLE
Ready for dinner?

RACHEL
What happened to the maestro of
mowing? Got more spots in the grass
than a Dalmatian.

Kyle turns to speak into the house.

KYLE
Boys! Cruella has arrived?

ALICIA (V.O.)
Oh my God!

Alicia grabs a watering can and scurries away from the
unfolding catastrophe. She beelines towards the shed on the
deck.

CLOSE ON: The shed doors open to see Alicia staring into the
shed.

ALICIA
Putting this away.

ALICIA (V.O.)
Do not look back at the carnage.
Everything has a place. This looks
like a good place for this thing.

She places the watering can in the saw location. Turning towards the sliding doors, Rachel enters the house as Kyle releases the stress with an exhale. Alicia walks towards and under his arm.

ALICIA
You survived. Bit surprised.

KYLE
Go wash your hands. I'm going to work on digging my grave. I'll be needing it soon.

CUT TO:

INT. AVERYS DINNING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

ANGLE ON: Alicia walks through the dining room into the hall. Kyle closes the door then sits with his sons at the table of summer FRUIT, RABBIT FOOD and a giant TURKEY. MASON (15yrs, boy) fills his mouth with a fork of turkey while his brother PATRICK (10yrs, boy) reloads his spoon with a pea.

KYLE
(glaring at Mason)
We wait for everyone to sit before starting.

MASON
(mumbling)
I need more food.

Patrick flings a pea into his brother's forehead.

PATRICK
You need manners.

Kyle SMILES as Rachel sets the can shaped CRANBERRY SAUCE.

KYLE
Patrick. Mason. Truce. I can't believe you're mine.

RACHEL
I can.

Patrick surveys the table to gather a feel of situation. He sees MIXED emotions on faces.

PATRICK
I want chicken nuggets!

RACHEL
(curtly)
No! We have one sit down dinner a
week. Try to be civil. Alicia!

CUT TO:

INT. AVERYS BATHROOM - CONTINUOUS

CLOSE ON: Alicia is WASHING her hands.

ANGLE ON: Alicia dries her hands on a SUMMER TOWEL and
relaxes as she FAKES a smile in the mirror. A last exhale,
she turns and exits to the hall then enters the dining room.

CUT TO:

INT. AVERYS DINNING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Close On: Rabbit food. Wiggling cranberry sauce. A perfect
TURKEY. Alicia takes her seat.

PATRICK
How was the dig?

ALICIA
Fun. You should try it. Go outside.

PATRICK
I thought about it, then I thought
about video games. Wasn't much of a
competition.

MASON
Is it ever a competition?

PATRICK
If electricity's out, batteries are
dead and I have no other options,
then it's a tie.

KYLE
Alright. You know the drill.

RACHEL
Kyle! Kids ...
(scanning table)
Bow your heads and a moment of
silence.

The table falls silent. Everyone less Alicia bow their heads.
Alicia corners her eye on Kyle.

ALICIA (V.O.)

Dad. You always break first then wait for mom. Predictable as the sunrise.

A moment of Grace from Rachel passes. Kyle breaks his hands and eyes lift to glance at his wife. He pauses for the rest of the minute. Rachel ends her prayer.

RACHEL

Amen!

ALICIA

(without hesitation)

Dad. I love you, but if you were a wild animal, I think you'd be extinct.

Shock fills their faces. Alicia smiles, reaches over and grabs a spoonful of CRANBERRY. She fills her plate first.

ALICIA (V.O.)

Victory! Alicia says go!

Kyle doubles his mashed potato. Mason passes the RABBIT FOOD while watching Patrick precisely place each strawberry to make a mosaic in his food.

RACHEL

Hey, Bob Ross. It's food not a landscape.

As Patrick strategically places a broccoli tree...

PATRICK

Happy ... little ... trees.

Rachel smirks at the humor she didn't know she needed.

RACHEL

Can we finish without a brawl breaking out this week? Last weeks food fight was unnecessary, unreasonable and took two baths to get the honey out of Mason's hair.

MASON

I still have a bald spot on the right side.

PATRICK

Looks like an improvement to me.

Patrick watches his broccoli trees FALL to the plate. The family begins to enjoy the meal.

CUT TO:

INT. AVERYS UPSTAIRS HALLWAY - EVENING

LOW ANGLE: Mason leans from the doorway to fire a NERF Missile at an annoyed Alicia. It misses the girl, but Patrick takes a Nerf missile to his leg. Alicia frustrated enters her and SLAMS her door shut.

CUT TO:

INT. AVERYS ALICIA BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS

Alicia's room (light blue 12 x 14 with a closet). She examines her closet which is organized by color and style. She places her shirt in the proper place. A glance to the window, then a few steps towards the BAOBOB TREE painted onto the wall with small WOOD SHELVES adorned with bracelets, trinkets, and pennies. She places the pocketknife onto a ledge.

ALICIA

Everything has a place. Now-

Alicia steps LEFT to take in her floor to ceiling BOOKCASE. She scans her way past: History to Mystery: A telling adventure; Five Bridges to Nowhere; Animal Farm. She pulls out a book Clothes and Style.

CLOSE ON: Thumbing through the appendix

ALICIA (O.S.) (CONT'D)

A. B. C. Cape, Cashmere, Capri,
Corset. Page 47.

(thumbs to page)

Agg! Abigail didn't wear a
croissant. It was a corset. Be
kinda silly to wear a pastry.

She places the book back, walks to her bed, and falls into her blankets. As she glances at the ceiling...

ALICIA (CONT'D)

Only one and a half days of school
left then freedom.

Alicia turns to her nightstand to turn the light off.

CUT TO BLACK.